Application to participate in the StartSpace Challenge 2026

Thank you for your interest in applying to the StartSpace Challenge.

Please read the Program Guidelines to find out more about eligibility requirements, application process and program outcomes before submitting your application: https://startspacehq.com/startspace-challenge-program-guidelines/

1. Your first name *

   Robin

2. Your last name *

   Langer

3. Your email address *

   langer.robin@gmail.com

4. Your phone number

   Enter your answer

5. Name of your business (if applicable)

   0413710989

6. Are you a current StartSpace member?

Applicants who are not yet members may apply for a free 12-month StartSpace membership prior to submitting their application.

- (●) Yes
- ( ) Not yet

Alignment with the Challenge

The following questions align with selection criterion 1. See program guidelines for more detail.

7. What excites you most about the StartSpace Challenge and which part resonates with you? *

Young people don't lack access to information — they're drowning in it. What they lack is the skill to evaluate, argue, and think from primary sources.

8. What assumptions do you currently have about young people (12 – 18) and their library experiences? *

They are distracted, overwhelmed, and drowning in information they haven't been taught to evaluate. They can find answers instantly but can't tell good answers from bad ones.

Founder mindset and openness to co-creation

The following questions align with selection criterion 2. See program guidelines for more detail.

9. Are you currently exploring an idea or early solution in this problem space? *

- ( ) No, I'm starting from the problem
- (●) Yes, I have an early concept
- ( ) Yes, I have an early MVP

10. In what direction would you like to take the solution you are currently working on?

Please tell us more about your initial idea and how you imagine it could evolve through co-creation with State Library Victoria.

We've built Tech World — a multiplayer 2D game platform in Flutter with AI characters, real-time chat, and an in-game challenge system. https://github.com/enspyrco/tech_world

Concept: The Gates. AI characters are placed throughout the library — both as augmented reality encounters on the student's phone camera and as guards on a digital map that mirrors the library floor plan. Each character holds a position grounded in a real historical primary source. The student must persuade the character through written argument to "open the gate." To build a winning argument, they need to find and read the source material. The game sends them to the catalogue. The catalogue sends them to a shelf. They read because they need to win.

We have compiled a list of 63 primary historical sources which might be suitable for this game.

The co-creation we're imagining:
- Librarians select the sources from our list (or add their own) based on what's actually on SLV's shelves
- Librarians place the gates — deciding which AI characters live near which sections of the library
- Librarians play the Miranda role ("The Diamond Age" - Neil Stepheson) — observing student progress, nudging when stuck, using their knowledge of the collection as a superpower the AI doesn't have.
- We build the mirror map of SLV's floor plan using our existing map editor, so the digital game world matches the physical space
- We test together — 5–10 students, in the library, and we learn what works and what we got wrong

The technology is largely built. What we need from SLV is the thing no technology can provide: deep knowledge of the collection, understanding of how young people actually move through the space, and librarians willing to experiment.

11. How would you work with SLV to ensure an audience-centred MVP (Minimum Viable Product)? *

Start with the librarians. They see young people in the building every day — they know what works and what doesn't. We'd pick the sources together from our list of 63, based on what's actually on SLV's shelves. Then we'd all read them — you can't build a game around a source you haven't sat with.

Month 1: choose sources, read them, build a map of the library, place the gates.
Month 2: put it in front of 5–10 teenagers and watch what happens.
Month 3: fix everything they showed us was wrong.

The students are the test. If they don't walk to the shelf and pick up the book, we've failed. That's what we're measuring.

Capability and capacity

The following questions align with selection criterion 3. See program guidelines for more detail.

12. What skills currently exist within your team that are relevant to building and testing an MVP? *

Examples might include: product design, UX/UI, software development, no-code tools, user research, prototyping, testing with users, content design, or project delivery.

Nick Meinhold — Built the Tech World game platform. App development (Flutter, Firebase), AI integration, game design, map editor, augmented reality. Interest in history (particularly primary sources) and persuasive writing.

Robin Langer — Mathematician. Curriculum design — compiled the 63 primary sources and designed the gate progression. Prompt engineering for the AI characters. The annoying one who reads everything and asks difficult questions.

Between us: A working multiplayer game engine that ships to iOS, Android, macOS, and web. We can prototype and test with users immediately.

What we don't have: User research with teenagers, library science expertise, knowledge of SLV's collection. That's what we're here for.

13. Have you previously built or tested a prototype, MVP, or early product (in this or another project)? *

- ( ) Yes
- (•) No

14. If yes, please briefly describe what you built and your role in it.

There's a first time for everything.

15. What kind of support would be most valuable to you to deliver a workable MVP during the program? *

Select up to three

- [ ] Product scoping and MVP definition
- [ ] Technical guidance (architecture, tooling, feasibility)

- [ ] UX / service design and prototyping
- [x] User research and testing
- [ ] Delivery planning and prioritisation
- [x] Access to State Library Victoria domain expertise (education, technology, procurement)
- [x] Mentor feedback on iteration and decision-making
- [ ] Other

16. How would you ensure that your team can deliver a workable MVP within the program timeframe? *

The game engine already exists — multiplayer, AI chat, maps, terminals, cross-platform. We're not building from scratch, we're configuring what's built. The MVP is three gates, six sources, and a map of one section of SLV. That's prompt design, a Firestore collection, and an afternoon with the map editor.

The hard part isn't technical — it's getting the sources right and testing with real students. That's why the program timeline works: month 1 to choose and read, month 2 to test, month 3 to fix. We'd rather ship three gates that actually make a teenager walk to a shelf than ten gates that look good in a demo.

17. Can you commit to participating between May–July (one day per month for ~4 hours in person), including sessions and follow-up work? *

- (●) Yes
- ( ) No

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